

Reference Services in the Library

Lesson 5: Using Electronic Resources

Using Electronic Resources - Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Electronic resource types** – e books, online journals, and subject specific databases.
2. **Authentication methods** – institutional proxy, VPN, and single sign on (SSO) via library login.
3. **Search strategies** – keyword vs. controlled vocabulary, advanced filters, and Boolean operators.
4. **Access shortcuts** – bookmark pages, use browser extensions, and save citations with reference managers.
5. **Legal and ethical use** – copyright basics, fair use limits, and proper citation.

Summary

Electronic resources have become the backbone of modern research, giving instant access to a vast collection of scholarly books, peer reviewed articles, and specialised databases. To retrieve these materials you typically start at your library's website, select the resource (e book, journal, or database), and log in using your institution's credentials. Most libraries support a single sign on (SSO) system that authenticates you automatically when you are on campus or connected through a VPN/proxy, eliminating the need to remember multiple passwords.

Effective searching goes beyond typing a phrase into a search box. Knowing whether a resource uses keyword indexing or a controlled vocabulary (e.g., MeSH, IEEE Terms) lets you craft more precise queries. Use Boolean operators (AND, OR, NOT), phrase searching with quotation marks, and field tags (title, author, abstract) to narrow results. Once you locate a resource, you can download PDFs, read online, or export citations directly to tools like Zotero or EndNote. Always respect copyright—download only what your license permits and cite every source correctly.

Important Points

- **Start at the library portal** – it aggregates all licensed e resources and provides the correct login path.
- **Authentication options**
 - On campus: automatic IP authentication.
 - Off campus: VPN, proxy URL (e.g., `https://proxy.university.edu`), or SSO login page.
- **Quick login steps**
 1. Click the "Login" or "Access" button on the resource's landing page.
 2. Choose your institution from the list.
 3. Enter your university username/password (or be redirected if already on VPN).
- **Search tips**
 - Use *advanced search* to combine fields (title /+ /author).

- Apply filters: publication date, peer reviewed, full text only.
- Save search queries for future alerts.
 - **Downloading & citing**
- Look for PDF, EPUB, or HTML full text icons.
- Export citation in RIS, BibTeX, or plain text.
- Record the DOI or stable URL for reference lists.
 - **Ethical use**
- Do not share downloaded files beyond personal use unless the license permits.
- Cite all sources according to your discipline's style guide (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.).

Examples

Example 1 – Accessing an e book

1. Go to the university library homepage !' **E Books**.
2. Search "Introduction to Public Health".
3. Click the title; a pop up shows "Full Text – PDF".
4. Click **Login** !' select your university !' enter credentials !' PDF opens.
5. Use the toolbar to download, highlight, or export the citation to Zotero.

Example 2 – Searching a scholarly database (e.g., PubMed)

1. From the library portal, choose **Databases** !' PubMed.
2. Advanced search: `("climate change"[MeSH Terms]) AND ("mental health"[Title/Abstract])`.
3. Apply filters: **Publication dates 2018 2023**, **Free full text**.
4. Review results, click an article title, then click **Full Text** !' login if prompted.
5. Export the citation (RIS) to your reference manager and note the PMID for later use.

Quick Review

1. What are the three main categories of electronic resources covered in this lesson?
2. Describe the typical steps to log in to an off campus electronic journal using a VPN or proxy.
3. How can Boolean operators improve your search results in a database? Give an example.
4. Name two ways to export citations from an electronic article to a reference manager.
5. Why is it important to check the licensing terms before downloading an e book?

Further Reading

- **Advanced Database Searching** – Boolean logic, truncation, proximity operators.
- **Reference Management Tools** – Zotero, Mendeley, EndNote tutorials.
- **Open Access Publishing** – Understanding OA journals, pre print servers, and Creative Commons licenses.
- **Digital Copyright & Fair Use** – Legal frameworks for educational use of electronic materials.
- **Library Guides (LibGuides)** – Discipline specific resource lists and research tips.

